# Housing: Two Models of Public Authority

Reading 3 of 4: Home Forward, Detroit, and East Detroit’s two housing institutions

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## Reading the housing cases

This report compares the Housing and Revitalization Department and Housing Commission in Detroit with the Portland Housing Bureau and Home Forward. Sources are identified by the [D], [H] and [F] references. Reported findings retain their dates and attribution; an investigation does not establish misconduct.

## East Detroit’s two housing institutions

1. **City and County of East Detroit Housing Division (EDHD).** A city-county department, answerable to the executive and council through appropriations and public records. It runs local housing policy and programs: financing development and preservation, tenant and homeowner assistance, homelessness prevention, and coordination with planning and human services. It may manage locally financed housing or contracts, but cannot allocate an independent authority’s federal vouchers.
2. **East Detroit Regional Housing Authority (EDRHA).** An independent public housing authority with its own commission, management, budgets, federal housing agreements, property and rental-assistance operations, and accountability duties. Modeled

on Home Forward, it also serves participating communities beyond the city-county. It administers federal housing assistance and its portfolio, plus local or regional programs where agreements allow. The city-county cannot direct its board or take its records just because it serves city residents.

Both serve many of the same residents while maintaining separate budgets, boards, program rules and records. Households may encounter repeated intake and verification. The agencies must agree on any shared process.

## 1. The Detroit model

### Detroit HRD: a city department

Detroit's Housing and Revitalization Department (HRD) is a city office and the closest real precedent for EDHD. According to the city, it directs housing policy, manages HUD entitlement funds and city housing investments, finances new housing and preservation, supports homeowners and renters, and works with partners on homelessness. The city names its partnership with the independent Detroit Housing Commission. [D1] [D2]

Detroit's *2025–2030 Affordable Housing Strategy* targets preserving 10,000 affordable units and building 3,000 over five years. These are policy targets, not results, and are not scaled to East Detroit. [D3]

### Detroit Housing Commission: separate and federally accountable

The Detroit Housing Commission (DHC) is a public housing authority, governed separately from HRD.

- **Federal takeover.** After administrative, financial and management failures, HUD took control of DHC's operations on July 7, 2005. [D4]

- **Transition plan.** In January 2012, HUD announced a plan to return DHC to local control, requiring sustainable governance, an oversight agreement and performance improvements. [D5]
- **Return to local control.** DHC states that HUD released it from the recovery administrator on March 13, 2015. [D6]
- **Board.** Under Michigan law, a five-member board appointed by Detroit's mayor governs DHC. At least one member must be a resident of subsidized housing. Mayoral appointment does not make DHC a city department. [D6]

### Detroit's operating problems (reported findings)

- **Income and voucher recertification.** Outlier Media reported that understaffing caused long federal voucher backlogs. In April 2023, 221 of 1,960 recertifications due were complete. Reporting in 2024 found 1,747 delinquent recertifications still pending despite an outside contractor's help. Pending recertifications can mean wrong rents and subsidies. Landlords reported late payments; some stopped accepting DHC vouchers. [D7] [D8]
- **Capacity and unmet demand.** Outlier reported that for a period the agency used roughly 1,500 fewer vouchers than its capacity, partly for lack of staff. [D8]
- **Vacancy and building condition.** In a 2023 Outlier interview, the interviewer put public housing occupancy at about 78%. Later reporting put vacancy near 23–24% in September 2024, with problems collecting rent and deteriorating buildings. [D9] [D10]
- **Recovery, with limits.** In a 2025 follow-up, Outlier reported that DHC management said it had mostly cleared the recertification backlog. Management also said vacancy had fallen from 24% to 14% and all 15 complexes had passed that year's HUD inspections. The same article reported residents whose problems persisted. These are reported outcomes and management statements for that period, not proof that every resident's problem was resolved. [D11]

A shared digital form cannot fix these problems alone. Staffing, authority, incentives and financing are part of the service.

## 2. Home Forward

Home Forward is a public corporation and the housing authority for Portland and Multnomah County, including Gresham and east Multnomah County. It states that it is not part of Portland city government. It runs housing assistance, affordable properties and related services, plus some programs for the city, the county and other partners. [H1]

### Board and accountability

Home Forward has a nine-member volunteer commission: four Portland representatives, two from Gresham, two from Multnomah County and one housing-program participant. The board sets policy, approves the budget and hires the executive director. The appointing governments shape who serves; they do not run daily operations. [H2]

Portland's own Housing Bureau finances affordable housing, supports preservation and runs local housing policies. Like Detroit's HRD and DHC, Portland pairs a city bureau with a separate authority, the pattern East Detroit follows. [H3]

### Federal flexibility: Moving to Work

Home Forward joined HUD's Moving to Work (MTW) demonstration on April 1, 1999. MTW gives selected public housing authorities limited flexibility over funding and administration, within federal conditions and reporting. It gives a city no unrestricted access to federal records and guarantees neither more housing nor sound management. In October 2026, Home Forward was reportedly considering changing its MTW participation, partly to address voucher funding. [H4] [H5]

### An operating and financial crisis

Table 1. Home Forward, 2025–2026: what was reported, and when

| When | Reported finding | What to examine |
|---|---|---|
| November–December 2025 | A November vacancy report described 956 of 6,847 units vacant, about 14%. Later coverage rounded the count to 955. The agency cited damaged units, market conditions and other causes. A high vacancy count does not mean every unit was ready to rent. [H6] | Unit condition, affordability, waiting lists, location, eligibility and leasing speed |
| February 2026 | Data supplied by Home Forward showed an average of 185 days to fill a vacancy in 2025. Buildings it managed directly averaged 172 days; contractor-run buildings had different averages. [H7] | Who owns each handoff, management contracts, how long units are actually available to lease |
| February–March 2026 | Reporting identified high vacancy, lost rent revenue, weakening debt-service coverage, tenant safety concerns and uneven performance among contracted property managers. A March report described one manager averaging 292 days to fill units. [H8] [H9] | Contractor oversight, financial feedback loops, resident safety |
| April–May 2026 | Willamette Week reported more than $100,000 in agency-funded CEO travel during 2023–2025, based on public records. On April 29, Home Forward announced that CEO Ivory Mathews would resign effective May 1; Michael Buonocore became interim chief. Officials and residents questioned the board's oversight. [H10] [H11] | Board scrutiny, conflicts of interest, executive reporting, leadership and public accountability |
| August 2026 | The Oregon Government Ethics Commission voted to investigate the former CEO's travel spending. The vote opened a full investigation, which is not a finding of misconduct. [H12] | Accusation vs. preliminary grounds vs. formal finding |
| October 26, 2026 | Home Forward's interim director estimated a $38 million budget gap for 2027. The director said the 2026 shortfall had grown from an earlier estimate of $13.8 million to nearly $38 million. A possible $28 million HUD shortfall payment for 2026 was not guaranteed. Options discussed: staff cuts, lower administrative spending, changing tenants' share of rent, and reconsidering MTW terms. The proposed tenant changes were expected to affect 12,356 households. [H5] | Forecasting, federal-fund dependence, cost shifts to tenants, who may change benefits |

Intense unmet need can coexist with all of these problems, and no single figure shows the cause. Vacant units include ones needing work, ones with different affordability restrictions, and ones whose rents may not compete with some market offers. Ask what causes each delay or vacancy.

An authority with public representation and formal controls can still fail at oversight. MTW flexibility cannot replace accurate financial reporting, adequate staffing, property performance or a functioning board.

## 3. Two precedents for two East Detroit institutions

Table 2. Detroit, Portland and East Detroit compared

| Question | Detroit: city department + DHC | Portland: Housing Bureau + Home Forward | East Detroit |
|---|---|---|---|
| Municipal housing office | HRD: policy, investment, production, preservation, homelessness [D1] | Housing Bureau: finance, local protections [H3] | EDHD; must take part |
| Separate authority | DHC: federally accountable; five-member board appointed by the mayor [D6] | Home Forward: independent public corporation; nine commissioners, several jurisdictions [H1] [H2] | EDRHA, independent and regional |
| Who it serves | Detroit, with federal and development partners | Portland, Gresham, rest of Multnomah County | East Detroit plus participating neighbors |
| Separate sources of money | City and entitlement funds vs. authority assistance and property finance | Local funds vs. federal vouchers, property revenue, other sources | Separate funds; terms for joint projects |
| Failures highlighted | Recertification backlogs, staffing, occupancy, inspections and property problems [D8] [D11] | Vacancy turnover, debt pressure, forecast gap, governance and oversight [H7] [H5] | None assumed; examine whatever local evidence exists |
| Possible cooperation | Development, preservation, homelessness referrals and resident services | Housing finance, shared projects, landlord relations and property operations | Defined intake, referrals, local assistance, housing placement, record correction, financial coordination |
| Why they may disagree | Independent duties and federal voucher administration | Regional constituency, separate board, funding restrictions | EDRHA may refuse integration or ask for contract conditions |

### What overlap tells us

- Savings to investigate: duplicate intake, repeated address checks, conflicting program directories, untracked staff referrals,

repeated landlord requests, inconsistent vacancy reporting, and help desks with no clear handoff.

- Work that should stay separate: program-specific federal eligibility and appeals; HUD voucher funding; property ownership and debt; inspections and habitability; city appropriations; regional board accountability; and resident confidentiality.
- A possible harm: more referrals to programs with no funding, staff, available unit or willing landlord. Faster screening can lengthen a queue when the bottleneck is housing supply or leasing, not intake.

## 4. One household, two agencies

Consider a household that is behind on rent and may lose its home.

Table 3. Who could do what for a household facing eviction

| Step | City Housing Division could… | Regional Housing Authority could… | Other participants |
|---|---|---|---|
| Understand the need | Offer city-funded prevention, navigation help or a referral | Identify an existing voucher, lease or property relationship, where authorized | Household, landlord, advocates |
| Check address and identity | Use a municipal address or residency service under adopted rules | Use its own records and HUD verification rules | GIS, county human services, HUD |
| Apply program rules | Decide eligibility for local funds | Decide eligibility, rent calculations, and voucher or lease rules | State or federal program administrators |
| Find available help | Allocate a limited city-funded grant | Confirm voucher budget, available property, subsidy and inspection requirements | Finance, property manager, landlord |
| Deliver a result | Pay a qualifying landlord, or issue a local decision or referral | Issue or adjust assistance, or offer a qualifying unit under program terms | Resident, landlord, courts where relevant |
| Correct errors and handle complaints | Correct the local case; allow appeals under city rules | Correct its voucher or tenancy record; use the required review process | Original record holder, any independent appeal body |

A shared application or verified-status exchange would require agreement on which records are sent, for what purpose, and who corrects errors. Each agency remains responsible for its own income verification and eligibility decisions.

### Federal limits on “one-click housing”

One-click housing approval depends on several separate federal and local requirements.

- **Income verification.** HUD already runs the Enterprise Income Verification (EIV) system, using income and benefit data from authorized federal arrangements. Public housing authorities use it under program rules. It is not a general city tax or payroll registry for citywide benefits. See HUD’s description and 24 CFR § 5.233. [F1] [F2]
- **Vouchers.** Housing Choice Vouchers require federal verification and reexamination, so an income flag alone does not show a funded voucher or suitable unit exists. A city may fund its own rent relief, but an interface change cannot create more federal vouchers. [F1] [F2] [F3]
- **Eviction court.** Automatic court stays require legal authority beyond a housing service. Court rules, notice, case status, landlord action and judicial authority need an actual legal basis. A housing authority’s automated referral cannot cancel a court case.

Reliable verification can reduce repeat paperwork. The agencies must still settle who operates the process and who handles corrections.

## 5. Questions for agency leaders

- Where do the city division and regional authority ask households to provide the same information?
- Which delays come from intake, staffing, inspections, funding, available units or landlord participation?
- What would a coordinated referral or leasing process require from both agencies?

- How would each agency maintain its own records, appeals and financial accountability?

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